Kamakoti recalls, “I was unable to clear the IIT entrance examination, so I joined Sri Venkateswara College of Engineering. The college was situated in a remote area, nearly 40 kilometres away from my home, with limited bus transportation. I was fortunate to have exceptional professors like Prof. S.D. Nigam, Prof. Venkatesha Nayak Sujeer, Prof. Raja Raja Verma, Prof. Thirumalpad, and Prof. N. Venkateswaran, who were from renowned educational institutions, who provided me with valuable guidance in subjects like computer architecture, physics, chemistry, and electronics.”

It was during his engineering college years that Prof. Kamakoti was introduced to the field of Computer Science & Electronics. He elaborates, “In my college days, computer science was a subset of electronics. We studied some programming languages like BASIC and COBOL, but our curriculum primarily focused on digital and analogue circuits, and computer architecture courses. Additionally, I began exploring advanced concepts related to hardware implementation of reconfigurable computing during my engineering days. At that time, FPGAs were not as prevalent as they are today, and I worked with something known as a programmable array of adders. These hexagonal elements were like the FPGAs we have today, and I was involved in developing a self-reconfiguring, fault-tolerant programmable array. We designed logic, lookup tables, and defined the data path and control paths. This work led to the creation of a logic block observer called built-in logic block observer (BILBO).” Notably, this was a time before the internet, so all his research and work relied heavily on extensive library access.

Reflecting on his college years, he also shares a profound commitment and vow he made during this period. “During my college days, I had the

*Prof. Kamakoti with wife and kid*

privilege of being in the presence of my Guruji, the Acharya of Kanchi Kamakoti Peetam Sri Chandrashekarendra Saraswati. He advised me to stay in India and contribute to the country through my work. I took a solemn vow that I would not travel abroad, obtain a passport, nor leave India. I resolved to stay in India and dedicate myself to serving the nation. Hence, I continued my PhD here, and to this day, I do not possess a passport.”

## Art-integrated learning

During his school and college years, Prof. Kamakoti began experimenting extensively with Carnatic music and the violin. He even developed a unique approach to memorising complex mathematical equations using musical rhythms. He recalls, “I remember struggling with certain intricate organic chemistry formulas. At that time, I transformed them into equations resembling music with mathematics and memorised them with the help of musical rhythms. Looking back, this creative memorisation method was quite effective. Find what you love in whatever you do, and you will automatically love and get deeply involved in your action.”

Prof. Kamakoti also had the privilege of forming a close relationship with the legendary singer and Bharat Ratna award recipient Late M.S. Subbulakshmi, a renowned singer whom he held in great affection.

As his father was assisting M.S. Subbulakshmi in Sanskrit, Prof. Kamakoti had the opportunity to